Curriculum of the Body: A Foucauldian Analysis of the Physical and Emotional Violence Inflicted on Female Students in Indian Schools

Problem, Impact, and Cycle of Dehumanization

This research explores the "Curriculum of the Body," an insidious, implicit curriculum that perpetuates a culture of oppression and dehumanization in both public and private schools, particularly impacting female students. This hidden curriculum manifests through the constant surveillance of girls' bodies in the form of rigid rules surrounding clothing, behavior, and social interactions, enforced through moral policing. Transgression of these norms result in the character-assassination of the female students, and their deliberate exclusion from opportunities of growth and learning.

Teachers, and larger school ecosystems play a key role in perpetrating this violence—female students who transgress norms of clothing, behavior, morality, and "propriety" are labelled as "promiscuous" or a "bad influence" which sexualizes them, and restricts their access to meaningful learning and leadership opportunities. However, teachers are victims of similar violence, surveillance, and regimented patriarchy, and therefore perpetuate oppressive dynamics over their students to reclaim a sense of autonomy which they otherwise lack in their own lives.

The findings reveal that such surveillance leads to emotional and physical violence, negatively impacting girls' self-perception, academic engagement, and future aspirations. As a result, many young women are left feeling inadequate and diminished, with lasting effects on their personal and academic growth. This oppressive school environment fosters a continuous cycle of dehumanization, obstructing the development of female students as confident and empowered individuals.

Recommendations and Pathways for Change

This study offers actionable insights that can inform programs and policies dedicated to advancing girls' education globally. The following recommendations are proposed:

(a) Incorporate reflective practices in teacher training to raise awareness about the Curriculum of the Body. Educators should be encouraged to critically examine their own experiences of gendered oppression and the ways these influence their pedagogies. Training must include open dialogues on topics such as gender, morality, sexuality, and power, fostering classroom environments where stigmas around these subjects are dismantled. These practices should be culturally responsive, allowing for localized approaches that cultivate critical consciousness, and help teachers better understand the power dynamics inherent in student-teacher relationships.

(b) Design curricula that center the lived experiences of female students, including narratives and vignettes that highlight their encounters with Curriculum of the Body—the bias, and dehumanization. Such inclusion not only humanizes students' realities but also serves as a mirror for educators to reflect on potentially harmful practices. School cultures must be

reimagined to celebrate student growth beyond conformity to rules—especially dress codes—and instead promote diverse, authentic expressions of identity and selfhood.

By foregrounding girls' voices and addressing the structural violence embedded in schooling systems, this study offers a transformative framework for meaningful reform. Its findings provide a foundation for educators, policymakers, and organizations to create inclusive, affirming educational spaces where girls can reclaim their identities, resist systemic sexism, and fully realize their potential. Ultimately, the research calls for a continued examination of entrenched patriarchal norms and opens up new avenues for documenting the varied and complex experiences of female students.